

From the Editor

*Hans Georg Gemünden, Dr. rer. oec. habil., Dr. h.c. rer. oec. et soc.,
Professor of Project Management, BI – Norwegian Business
School Department of Leadership & Organization, Oslo, Norway*



Photo credit: Markus Bullick

The first article from **Marte Pettersen Buvik** and **Sturle Danielsen Tvedt** on **“The Influence of Project Commitment and Team Commitment on the Relationship Between Trust and Knowledge Sharing in Project Teams”** examines the relationship among trust, commitment, and knowledge sharing. The authors include two different foci of commitment that are highly relevant to project teams: team commitment and project commitment. Their theory and findings show that propensity to trust and trustworthiness have a significant positive influence on team and project commitment and on the knowledge sharing climate and knowledge sharing behavior. The authors also posited that project and team commitment mediate the influence of the two trust-related constructs. This mediation was confirmed for project commitment, but not for team commitment; thus, project commitment, defined as a belief in the goals at hand and willingness to engage in the project turned out to be more crucial than team commitment, which did not mediate the influences of trust. The findings are in line with previous studies that have found trust to be a significant predictor of the sharing of tacit knowledge and add to the existing literature that project commitment is an important intervening variable for knowledge sharing in projects. The editor of this article was Hans Georg Gemünden.

The second article is also on project teams. **Amin Akhavan Tabassi, Kamand M. Roufehaei, Abu Hassan Abu Bakar** and **Nor’Aini Yusof** address the theme: **“Linking Team Condition and Team Performance: A Transformational Leadership Approach.”** The authors argue that team building and team development can be studied as ongoing processes that are crucial to project success. Their analysis shows that the team condition, which is defined as the factors that contribute to making a great team, has significant direct and indirect impacts on team performance. The six factors of the team condition are (1) contribution, (2) communication, (3) responsibility and accountability, (4) experimentation and creativity, (5) conflict and competition, and (6) interpersonal relationships. The transformational leadership behavior of team leaders shows a mediating role between the team condition and the performance. The sample is taken from projects in the construction industry. In order to reduce

the risk of common method variance, the research analysis was completed using 94 teams from three different sources, within which team members rated their leader’s transformational leadership behavior. The team leaders evaluated the team’s conditions, and, lastly, the supervisor of each team rated the team’s performance. The editor of this article was Hans Georg Gemünden.

The third article by **Marie Bengtsson** and **Lars Lindkvist**, **“Mapping the Road to Future Projects: Roadmapping as a Balancing and Transformation Process,”** shows how roadmapping can bring about an increased focus on explorative activity and a stronger future orientation in an organization. Based on an exciting longitudinal case study in a large technology-based firm, this article documents that it may take two or more strategic initiative projects to change the direction of an organization. The first change project, a radical technology vision, presented in the first roadmapping attempt, contributed to creating an awareness of the value of looking long into the future. As this was far from sufficient, a second more bottom-up driven attempt with a stronger focus on collaboration and new knowledge generation was initiated to further the desired change over. Interestingly, the case study points to the significance of visualizations as a means to supporting knowledge generation, as well as protecting exploration. The editor of this article was Hans Georg Gemünden.

The fourth article in this issue by **Tristano Sainati, Naomi Brookes, and Giorgio Locatelli** on **“Special Purpose Entities in Megaprojects: Empty Boxes or Real Companies?”** addresses infrastructure megaprojects, which typically cost more than US\$1 billion and are characterized by vast impacts on the economy, society, and environment; long-term commitment; high involvement of public actors, such as governments, turbulent environment; significant risk for the sponsors; and high organizational complexity. Such megaprojects involve hundreds of companies. Although megaprojects are important for modern economies and societies, they have a history of poor performance. Some of the explanations lie in the inherent complexity, difficulty, and uncertainty of the megaproject endeavor; others refer to governance challenges like strategic misinterpretations of decision makers, cultural distance and lack of effective collaboration between project stakeholders; and poor front-end problem analysis, business planning, and engineering and design. The current article concentrates on the governance issue from a contracting perspective. One of the formal governance instruments, widely used in megaprojects,

is the Special Purpose Entity or Vehicle (SPE/SPV). A formal definition of SPE is a key deliverable of this article. When SPEs are in place, megaprojects are statistically correlated with better schedule and budget performance (Brookes & Locatelli, 2015; Brookes, Locatelli, & Mikic, 2015). However, the term SPE is only defined vaguely. The legal, financial, and project management domains conceptualize the SPEs in different ways and their technical jargon results are quite fragmented. The authors address three research questions: (1) What is an SPE? (2) Which types of SPEs exist? (3) Why are SPEs used in megaprojects? The authors perform a systematic literature review of more than 3,000 documents published between 1960 and 2014, which were systematically analyzed. The definition of an SPE is: *"The Special Purpose Entity is a fenced organization having limited predefined purposes and a legal personality."* To answer the second research question, a set of ten distinctive features describing a SPE is used. The authors then discuss major issues of SPEs in the legal, financial, and project management domains and compare existing SPEs; overall, four outcomes are presented: the definition of SPE, the typology of existing SPEs, comparisons of existing SPEs, and descriptions of SPE uses in megaprojects. The editor of this article was Andrew Davies.

Muhammad Mubbashar Hassan, Sajid Bashir, and Syed Moqaddas Abbas investigate the following theme: **"The Impact of Project Managers' Personality on Project Success in NGOs: The Mediating Role of Transformational Leadership."** Their study examines the extent to which project managers' personality determines project success through the mediating mechanism of transformational leadership. The context of the study are nongovernmental projects that focused on education and healthcare. Data were collected from 170 project managers who were engaged in 10 different programs in various areas of Pakistan. The results of the study indicate that Extraversion, Agreeableness, and Openness to Experience are direct positive predictors of project success, whereas transformational leadership acts as a mediator of these relations. Conscientiousness has only an indirect effect on project success through transformational leadership. No relation was found between Neuroticism and project success. The editor of this article was Ralf Müller.

The sixth article in this issue by **Dominic D. Ahiaga-Dagbui, Peter E. D. Love, Simon D. Smith, and Fran Ackermann** **"Toward a Systemic View to Cost Overrun Causation in Infrastructure Projects: A Review and Implications for Research"** argues for a more comprehensive view. The methodological weaknesses in the dominant approaches adopted to explain cost overrun causation on infrastructure projects are explored in this article. A considerable amount of cost overrun research is superficial, replicative, and thus has stagnated the development of a robust theory to mitigate and contain the problem. Future research should move from single-cause identification and the traditional net-effect correlational analysis to a search for causal recipes through systems thinking and retrospective sensemaking to address the high-level interactions between multiple factors. This article presents a very insightful literature analysis, which deserves further discussion and reflection. The editor of this article was John Steen.

The final article in this issue is by **Jan Recker, Christoph Rosenkranz, Markus Hummel, and Roland Holten** on **"How Agile Practices Impact Customer Responsiveness and Development Success: A Field Study."** Agile information systems development methods have become popular; however, which specific agile practice to use remains unclear. The authors argue that three types of agile practices exist—for management, development, and standards—which affect the customer responsiveness of software teams differently. The authors examine this theory in a field study of a large organization. They find that agile practices improve software team response effectiveness or efficiency, but not both. Agile standards do not improve response mechanisms but are still important to successful information systems development. The findings help discriminating agile practices and yield insights into how information development can be improved by using the right practices in the best way. The editor of this article was Fred Niederman.

References

- Brookes, N. J., & Locatelli, G. (2015).** Power plants as megaprojects: Using empirics to shape policy, planning, and construction management. *Utilities Policy*, 36, 57–66.
- Brookes, N., Locatelli, G., & Mikic, M. (2015).** *Learning across megaprojects*. Brussels, Belgium: Megaproject COST Action.